

Another way to evaluate a school's social climate is to visit the school while classes are in progress. Focus on details. Are the halls swept, the walls freshly painted? Do the drinking fountains work? Notice the children's faces. How do they react when a teacher passes? Do the teachers smile at the kids or just hurry down the hall? Go out to the playground. Have the coaches done their job in organizing games? Or do the children sit quietly and polish their switchblades? In the administrative office, find out the number of kids, number of teachers, and the length of the school day and school year.

Arrange to see the principal, even if you get only a few moments of his time. If he's not there, make an appointment for the following day and keep it. Ask what he enjoys most about the school. Ask him to explain his biggest problems. Perhaps most important, ask him about the school's budget. If he had more money, what would he spend it on? Southern states spend less per student than California, Illinois, and Massachusetts. But statewide averages can mislead. School districts within a given state spend more or less than others. And some school districts spend it more wisely than others.

Even if your kids go to primary school, make sure you visit the high school as well. As likely as not, once you retire you'll stay put until Johnny finishes high school. When you visit the high school, talk to the kids. More than anyone else, frank teenagers can give you a feel for the school. Do the kids use drugs? Get into fights? Support the football team? Besides listening to what the teenagers say, size up the kids themselves. Would you be comfortable having Johnny bring them home as friends?

Chapter 5 suggests you move to the Third World to live a better life. In my opinion, retired parents living abroad should send their kids to an international private school. An international private school is *not* an overseas American school at \$600 per month per child. Rather, the international school you want has a local English or American headmaster and offers at least half a day of instruction in English. In Rio, for